Burmese democracy movement

It is difficult to understand reactions from within the Burmese democracy movement without acknowledging the historical trajectories of democratic thought in Myanmar. In particular, I argue that the values of unity and protection of the Bamar majority have been especially prominent in democratic thought before and since Burma's independence. And that these values inform current descriptions — by activists and opposition leaders — of the problems and solutions related to the country's democratization.

It is firstly important to note that the initial parliamentary period (1948–62) after independence — under Burma's first prime minister, U Nu — was one of great instability. There was a range of civil wars against both Communist uprisings and also disaffected ethnic minority groups. And there were also significant divisions among Bamar political leaders, eventually leading to a split in U Nu's ruling Anti Fascist People's Freedom League (or *hpasapala*) party. With continuing deep ethnic, religious, and ideological divisions, a key question for political leaders was how to maintain unity in the country and protect the future of the Bamar majority from both its internal and external threats.

U Nu, in particular, was intent on a form of "democracy" where benevolent leaders could unite the fragmented country. He praised the martyr U Aung San for his *cetana*, or benevolence (Houtman 1999, p. 62). In his introduction to U Nu's play *The Wages of Sin*, Law Yone (in Blum et al. 2013, p. 65) remarked:

> U Nu came close to quoting the Bible when he gave his concept of democracy: It is not he who says Lord, Lord who will enter the Kingdom of Heaven, but he who doeth the word of my Father. It is not everyone who says Democracy, Democracy that will find it, but he that doeth what democracy enjoins … democracy had not failed, but those professing it had failed democracy. In particular those who had preached it constantly had failed to practise it.

In other words, U Nu suggested that many people may talk about democracy, yet it was those who fulfilled the obligations of democracy who were most genuine — those who 'doeth what democracy enjoins' (Law Yone 1961, p. 1). The country of Burma could be knitted together for the first time through a democratic political system led by people with moral character and a willingness to put aside narrow vested interests for the benefit of the country.